William Zhao

Seeking a Summer 2027 Product Management internship

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Education

University of California, Santa Cruz — Expected 2028
B.A. Computer Science — *Santa Cruz, CA*

Experience

Co-founder, Product — Dec 2025 – Mar 2026
Muochi — *San Francisco, CA*

- Owned product end to end for a tool that turns branching slideshows into personalized digital gifts: the sender builds paths the recipient clicks through, then shares it as a link. Reached **115,000 users**.
- Scoped the product around an occasion with existing demand rather than building for a general use case, and shipped to that window; the launch produced $25K in revenue.
- Instrumented the retention funnel in PostHog and traced the 11% D1 ceiling to the product itself, not the funnel: gifting is occasion-bound, so there was no reason to come back.
- Ran session replays and cut signup, personalization, and the drag-and-drop editor from the path to first value; users went straight to a template, with payment deferred to customization.

Founder, Product — Jun 2024 – Dec 2025
CareerLoop — *Santa Cruz, CA*

- Built and owned an AI resume builder from problem definition through launch, reaching **30,000 users** with no paid acquisition.
- Cut onboarding from seven steps to three; 96% of signups completed it and built a resume, and 3.31% converted to paid, producing $30K over six months.
- Tested three monetization models against a 47% subscription churn rate: a carded free trial, a $1.99 tripwire, and one-time pricing. Shipped the model that matched observed behavior, since users bought more $9.99 single downloads than $19.99 unlimited, underestimating their own usage.
- Identified 4% D1 retention as a product-market problem rather than a funnel problem: a resume is built once.
- Shipped resume upload, bullet generation, and full rewrites, plus role matching against scraped job listings. Killed an AI career copilot before launch: the agent was inconsistent and the interface required teaching users a new interaction model, which the core flow did not.
- Covered by UC Tech News, Lookout Santa Cruz, and Santa Cruz Works.

Research Assistant — Sep 2023 – Jun 2024
The Humanities Institute, UC Santa Cruz — *Santa Cruz, CA*

- Built a translation pipeline that ingested large PDF corpora and ran them through OpenAI and other models; the faculty lead passed its output to graduate researchers, who evaluated quality against source texts.
- Shipped it as a web app rather than internal tooling so the humanities researchers could run translations themselves without touching a script. Python, Flask, deployed on Heroku.
- Translated the faculty lead's research goals into buildable requirements, scoping what was technically feasible, on a five-person research assistant team split across engineering and UI/UX.

Skills

Product	User research, roadmapping, prioritization, A/B testing, funnel and retention analysis, monetization design, data-informed decision making
Technical	Python, JavaScript/TypeScript, React, React Native, Django, PostgreSQL, OpenAI API & embeddings
Tools	PostHog, Microsoft Clarity, Stripe, Linear, Notion, Figma, Google Search Console